

Hawkish by Voice

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Holding the words fixed, the way Q&A sounds contains market-relevant information.

15-MINUTE RESEARCH TALK

Do markets react to how the FOMC sounds?

Same words

“Inflation remains elevated.”

Text-based tone is held constant



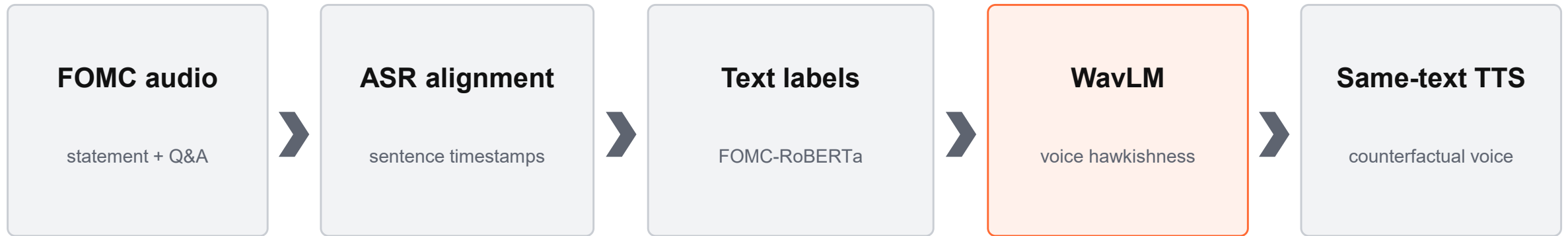
Different delivery

Human voice – same-text TTS

The difference isolates non-textual delivery signals

Voice gap = net hawkishness(human) – net hawkishness(TTS)

Each sentence is paired with itself



What is held fixed

The words, sentence boundaries, and underlying semantic content.

What the gap can include

Delivery plus speaker composition in the interactive Q&A—not only the chair.

89 press conferences yield 35,619 paired sentences

89

press conferences

35,619

clean sentences

30,671

Q&A sentences

2011–25

sample window

Held-out speech classification

0.9125

pooled AUC

0.8362

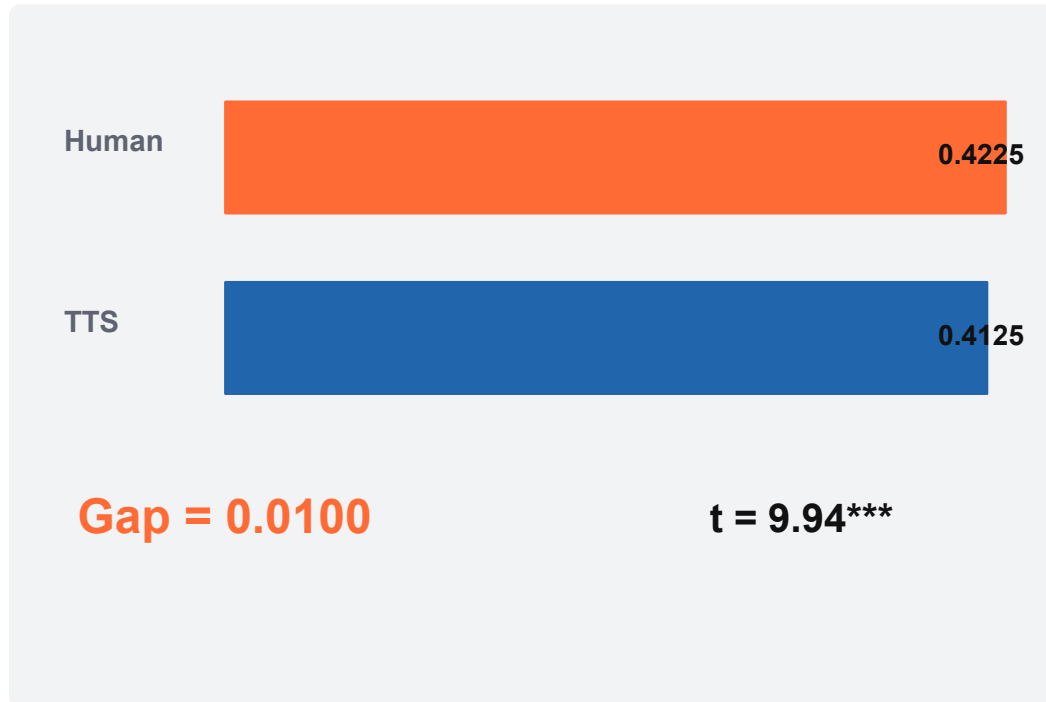
accuracy

0.8362

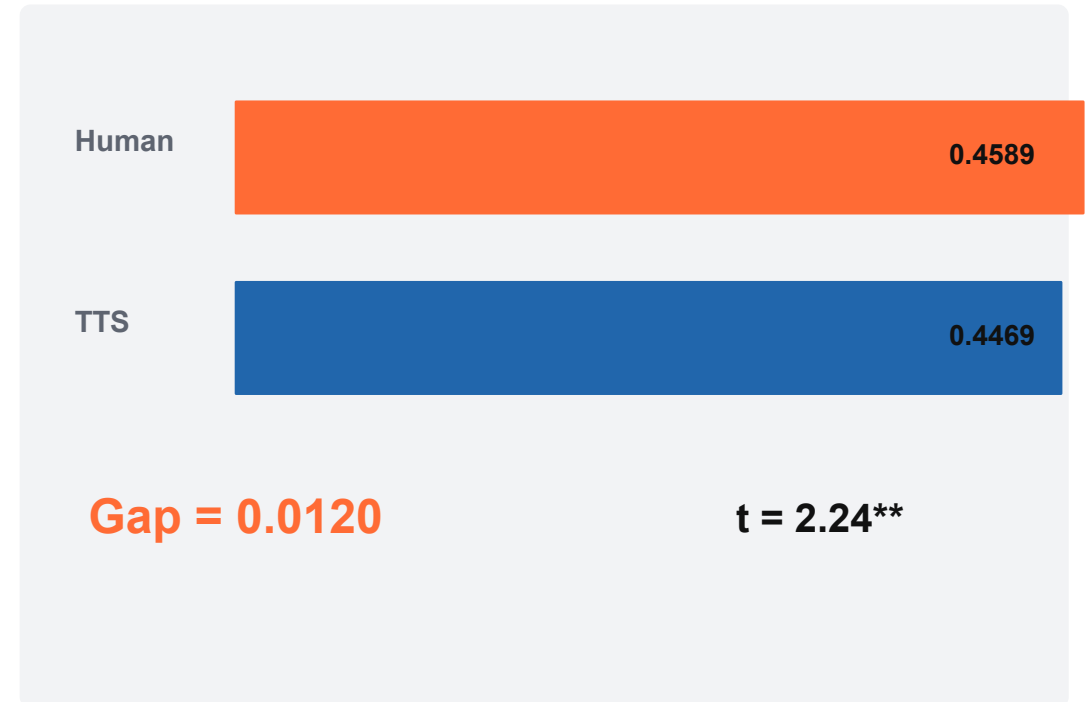
macro F1

Human Q&A is modestly more hawkish than TTS

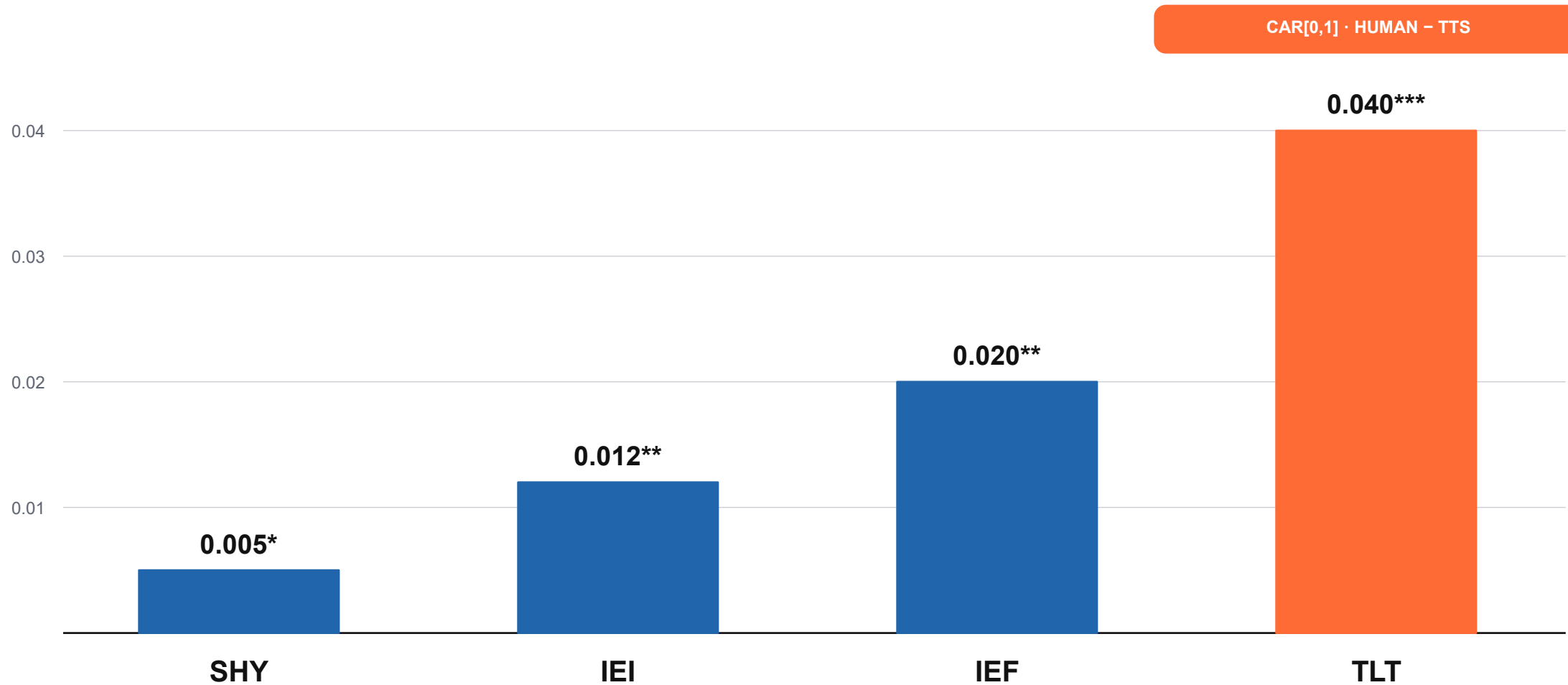
Sentence level



Meeting level

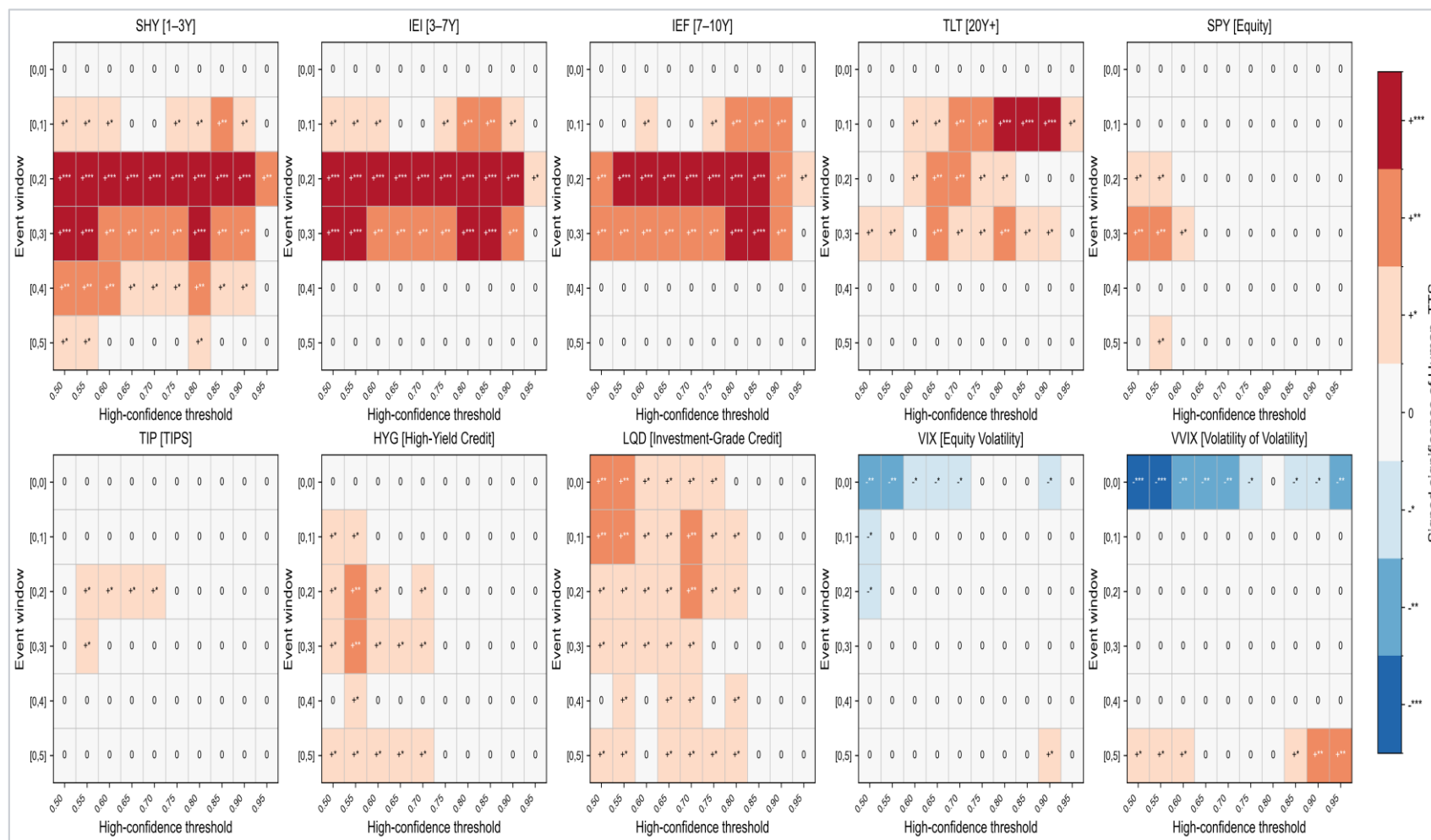


Treasury sensitivity rises with maturity



A 0.01 increase in the voice gap is associated with a larger two-day return at longer maturities.

The main effect is stable across design choices



Across thresholds

Signs persist across alternative high-confidence cutoffs.

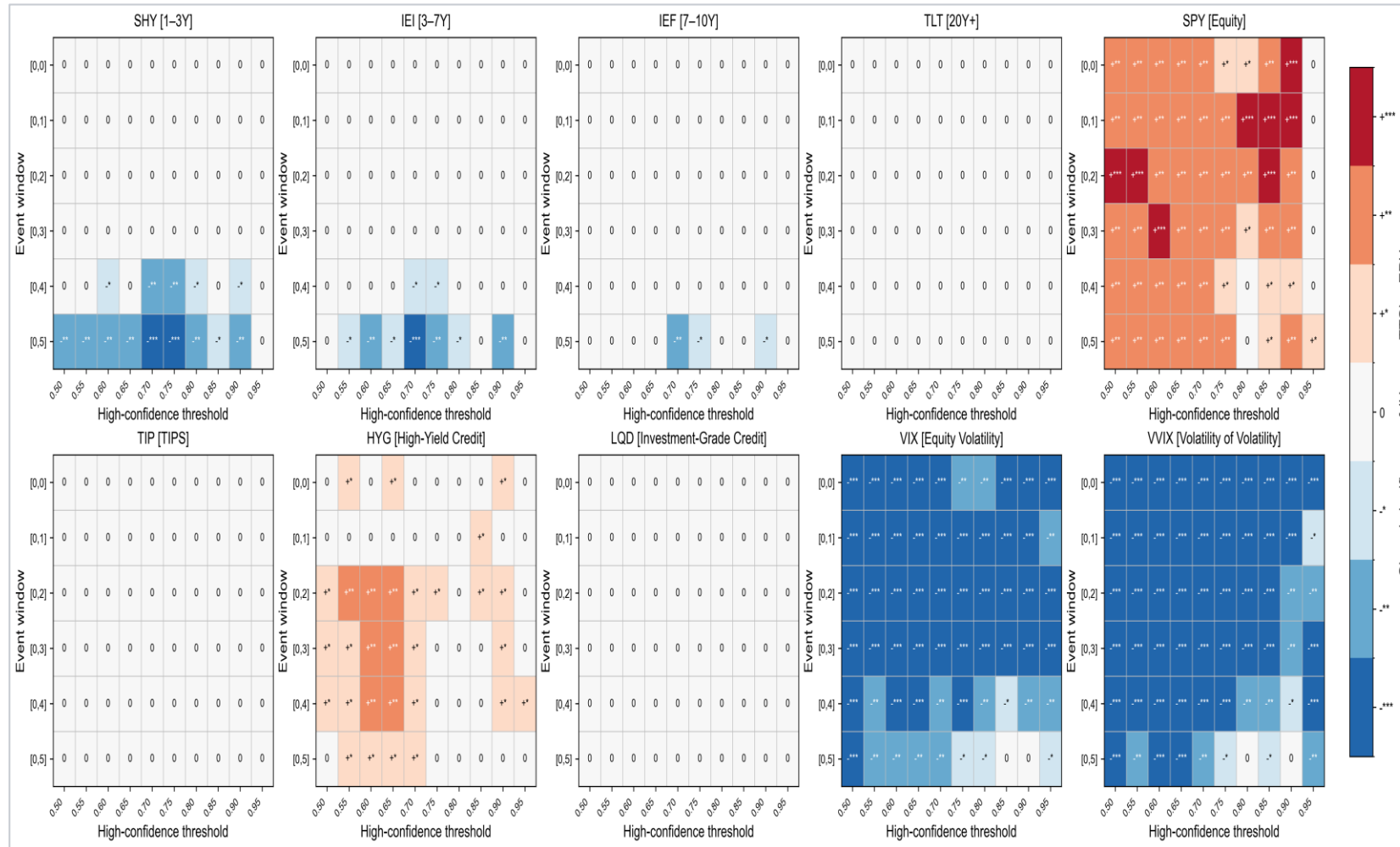
Across windows

Results are visible beyond one event-window choice.

Across assets

The strongest unconditional pattern is in Treasuries.

Policy uncertainty redirects the response



+0.0003

SPY × EPU

-0.058

VIX × EPU

-0.163

VVIX × EPU

Voice matters, but the estimand is broader than the chair

What we learn

Markets respond to non-textual information embedded in live FOMC Q&A, even after fixing the words.

What we do not claim

The coefficient is not a causal chair-only voice effect; reporters, moderator, and interaction matter.

Why it matters

Communication measurement should be multimodal—and evaluated against economic outcomes.

Bottom line: text and delivery are distinct channels of monetary-policy communication.